



Respecting privacy

When two people decide to sext with each other, there is usually an agreement that the pictures are only for the two of them. It is critical that they treat any sexts they receive with respect. Sharing sexts without permission is a violation of trust and privacy, and there may also be legal consequences.

ALERT!

Sexting and the law

In some states, if someone is under the age of 18 and they take or share a picture of themselves naked or in a sexually explicit pose, they are creating child sex abuse images, also known as child pornography. This is illegal.

Having a copy of child pornography is also illegal, which means that the person the sext is sent to is also potentially breaking the law. The consequences could include receiving a criminal record or even being sent to prison. If someone shares a sext with you, do not send the image on. Instead, report it to a parent or teacher.

Revenge porn

Revenge porn is when someone posts online a naked or sexually explicit image or video of someone else as a way of getting back at them for something. It is most often done by someone who was recently broken up with, and they typically use images that were sent to them as sexts during the relationship. Revenge porn can also refer to a situation in which friends who have fallen out with one another share pictures they had previously been sent in confidence.

Although there are laws being written to stop revenge porn, if the picture has been posted online and seen by many people, the damage has often already been done before any legal action can be taken.



△ Be aware of the risks

Even if the person who first posted the image online deletes it, others may have already copied it and posted it elsewhere.

Sexting issues

If a teen has sent or received a sext and is worried about the consequences, it's important to know what to do. The first step to take is to delete the image or video from all devices where possible, and, if it appears online, to contact the site and request for it to be taken down.



< Love and support

Parents should make clear to their teen that they can come to them for help with any problem.

TEEN HINTS

Getting help

- There are things that can be done to minimize the impact, but you need to act quickly. Ask the person not to share the image and to delete it from their phone. If the image appears online, notify the site and click the link to report abuse.
- Tell your parents. They may be angry at first, but it's better for them to hear it from you rather than someone else.
- If you're being blackmailed or your image has been shared as revenge porn, contact the police.

PARENT TIPS

Giving support

- Tell your teen they can come to you in case of a problem.
- If your teen has received a sexually explicit message, discourage them from sharing and tell them to report it.
- The law is not designed to punish a teen who has taken their own picture to experiment sexually, but rather those who profit from distributing sexual images.
- If your teen is being blackmailed or has been a victim of revenge porn, contact the police.